

Empathy Map

Says · Thinks · Does · Feels — the user, holistically

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

An Empathy Map is a canvas that captures what a user **says**, **thinks**, **does** and **feels** (often with pains and gains), building a shared, externalised picture of their experience. It surfaces gaps — for example, where what a user says diverges from what they truly feel.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Created by Dave Gray of XPLANE in the 2000s; refined in *Gamestorming* (2010) and widely taught by the Nielsen Norman Group.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Teams needed a simple way to synthesise messy interview and observation data into a single, human picture the whole team could align around.

FIGURE 1 · SAY · THINK · DO · FEEL



Figure 1. The four quadrants around the user, with pains and gains distilled underneath.

HOW IT IS USED

After research, the team populates each quadrant with evidence, then looks for tensions and unmet needs that point toward design opportunities and a point-of-view statement.

WHEN IT IS USED

During and after the Empathise phase, to consolidate research before Define.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

UX and service designers, product teams, marketers and researchers.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It turns empathy from a **feeling into an artefact** the team can build on, and directly feeds the Define stage — a bridge between research and framing.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Persona / User Profile *Slibrary 5*

Customer Journey Map *Slibrary 5*

Point of View (PoV) *Slibrary 6*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Gray, D., Brown, S. and Macanufo, J. (2010) *Gamestorming*. Sebastopol, CA: O'Reilly.

Gibbons, S. (2018) 'Empathy Mapping', *Nielsen Norman Group*. Available at: <https://www.nngroup.com/articles/empathy-mapping/> (Accessed: 20 July 2026).